

Beyond the Chat Box: AI at Your Desk

Audience Notes — Getting Started with Claude Cowork

Dr. Logan Kelly | Small Business AI Center

TBD 2026

Small Business AI Center

What is Claude Cowork?

Cowork is Anthropic's desktop AI mode where Claude works *with the files on your computer* instead of inside a chat tab. You point it at a folder, describe a result, and Cowork plans, executes, and saves real files back to that folder.

- **Reads your folders** — no more copy-paste, no more re-upload
- **Writes real files** — .docx, .xlsx, .pdf you can open and edit
- **Runs skills** — reusable mini-programs for repeating workflows
- **Uses connectors** — Slack, Gmail, QuickBooks, Calendar, more
- **Schedules tasks** — daily briefings or weekly reports automatically
- **Stays local** — runs in an isolated VM; files don't leave your machine

Cowork vs. Chat — when to use which

Chat	Cowork
One file at a time, re-uploaded	A folder Cowork can read and write
Text in a chat window	Real files saved back
Re-type the prompt each time	Skills, scheduled tasks, plugins
Files travel to the cloud	Runs in an isolated VM locally
Good for quick Q&A	Good for multi-step work in your files

Three Steps to Start

Step 1 — Install Claude Desktop

Download: claude.com/download — pick macOS or Windows.

- **Mac:** Apple Silicon (M1 or newer) required for Cowork
- **Windows:** Pro / Enterprise / Education (Hyper-V required); not Home
- **Plan:** Pro (\$20/mo), Max, Team, or Enterprise — not free tier
- **Install:** Admin rights needed on first install

Step 2 — Run `/setup-cowork`

In your first Cowork session, type `/setup-cowork` and press enter. Guided setup walks you through:

- Pick your role (small biz owner, lawyer, marketer, etc.)
- Install a plugin matched to that role
- Connect your tools — Slack, Google or Microsoft 365, QuickBooks, etc.
- Try a skill — your first repeatable workflow

Step 3 — Pick a Folder

Click **“Work in a folder”** in the chat bar. Cowork reads context from that folder and saves finished work back to it. You can change folders any time — it's just a permission scope.

Tip: make a fresh folder for each project. Cowork sees everything in it.

Demo 1: What's in My Folder?

Setup: point Cowork at a folder of business documents.

Prompt

Read everything in this folder. Then tell me:

1. What's here — a short index of files with one-line descriptions
 2. What needs my attention this week — anything time-sensitive, decisions owed, or follow-ups overdue
 3. What's not here that probably should be — gaps you'd ask me about
- Don't write any files yet — just report back.

Follow-up (if useful)

For the items you flagged as needing attention this week, draft a short reply or response for each one. Save the drafts as a single Word document in this folder called `Drafts_For_Review.docx`.

Demo 2: Saving Work as a Skill

Setup: after Demo 1, in the same Cowork session.

Prompt

Save what we just did as a skill called “Monday Briefing.” It should:

- Read the current working folder
- Produce the same 3-part report
- Run once per week — set it up as a Monday morning scheduled task

Tell me what you've saved and how I trigger it next week.

Follow-up (if useful)

What other workflows in my week look like good candidates to turn into skills? Don't build them — just suggest 3 or 4 based on what you've seen.

Three Things to Try This Week

1. **Install Claude Desktop** and run `/setup-cowork` once. Even if you don't use it daily — the install itself takes 10 minutes.
2. **Make a “Cowork sandbox” folder.** Pick a low-stakes folder (last quarter's invoices, an old project) and let Cowork read it. Get a feel for what it sees.
3. **Save one prompt you re-type as a skill.** The first time you find yourself pasting the same instructions twice, stop and turn it into a skill.

Privacy & Trust

- Cowork runs in an **isolated virtual machine** on your computer
- Files never leave your machine for training
- Network access is allowlisted
- You see what Cowork plans before it acts — approve, edit, or cancel each step

Contact

Logan Kelly, Ph.D.

Codirector, Small Business AI Center

Universities of Wisconsin

Office of Business & Entrepreneurship

Phone: 715-425-3335

Email: logan.kelly@business.wisconsin.edu

Professor of Economics

School of Business and Economics

University of Wisconsin–River Falls

Phone: 715-425-3335

Email: logan.kelly@uwrf.edu

Resources

- **Download:** claude.com/download
- **Get started guide:** support.claude.com → “Get started with Claude Cowork”
- **Three-step intro:** claude.com/resources/tutorials/get-started-in-claude-cowork-in-three-steps
- **Small business tutorial:** claude.com/resources/tutorials/using-claude-for-your-small-business